



“At the mid-level and above, roles are becoming more gender neutral. Women are opting for business-facing roles”

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who can use it to manage their personal and family responsibilities while remaining dedicated workers. They are also looking at longer paternity breaks that enable men to take care of their children and give women a chance to return to the workforce earlier rather than going on an extended maternity break. Crèches, daycare, nursing rooms and transport service are other facilities being offered to women workers.

“There is a wide scope of things that employers can do such as nudge them to reskill or add more skills, sponsor them for workshops to give them more confidence,” says Chakraborty of TeamLease.

Women leaders profiled in this issue believe that right from their childhood, their family remained a source of support, giving them the same opportunities that were given to the boys in the family, and this has translated into their spouses and children also treating them no

differently and understanding that chores related to the household have to be done by all. Most of them are now paying it forward by ensuring that their organisations are equitable and inclusive in their approach when dealing with women employees.

But a common sentiment echoed by most experts is that women, too, have to undergo a mindset change and have greater self-confidence as well as the belief that they can continue to work, whatever be the challenges.

“Women are also more inhibited and can lack confidence in the workplace,” says Chakraborty, adding that they also need to have the mindset that not working is not an option for them. “For men, it is a given that they will get a job and a regular income. But women have the option to stop working and tend to the household. Women have to move out of this thinking,” she says.

Raghuvanshi of Randstad India

also agrees that women need to have more courage and have to work harder to be more organised and disciplined. “If women get that right in their head that there is always a way, then they will be able to manage the (maternity or career) break time better and not take longer breaks that can make them redundant at the workplace. It is a mindset shift to come back to the workplace with shorter gaps of a year or six months,” she highlights.

It may not have been an easy journey to the top for the women on this year’s MPW list. Each of them has tackled challenges head on and has highlighted their fighting spirit as a key attribute that did not let them feel defeated or let down, no matter how insurmountable the difficulty may have been. Each of them is a glorious example and a reminder of the joys and the rewards that the path less taken can lead to. **BT**

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